<u>The Wider Historical Context of *An Inspector Calls*</u>

Please read this resource carefully and consider memorising a specific contextual fact for each of the 10 topics.
Most importantly, focus on the sections on the **Writer's Message** – memorise these for the *WHY* statements of your essays, where you move from close language analysis to considering Priestley's overall arguments.

1. 1912: A World on the Brink

• In 1912, Britain appeared secure: the empire was vast, industry was booming, and the ruling classes felt untouchable.
• Politicians and businessmen like Arthur Birling believed in stability and growth, yet Europe was already unstable. The **Triple Alliance (Germany, Austria-Hungary, Italy)** and **Triple Entente (Britain, France, Russia)** had created a fragile peace.
• The **arms race** and imperial rivalries meant war was imminent. The **First World War (1914–18)** killed over **16 million people**, shattering confidence in progress.
• Priestley's choice of 1912 is deliberate: it represents a society on the edge of collapse, blind to its own fragility.
• **Writer's Message:** The smug certainty of the Birlings reflects the blindness of the powerful. Priestley warns his audience that ignoring global tensions and social responsibility leads to disaster.
➡️ *In your essay:* Set in 1912, just before the First World War exposed the arrogance of the ruling classes, Priestley uses the Birlings' complacency to mirror a society blindly confident in its own stability.

2. The Edwardian Class System

• Britain's social structure in 1912 was steeply hierarchical: the aristocracy and industrial elite dominated wealth and power.
• Only about **2% of the population owned most of the land**, while millions lived in poverty.
• The working classes relied on charity or the harsh **Poor Law of 1834** for support.
• Birling embodies a man striving for upward mobility, using business and marriage to gain respectability.
• **Writer's Message:** Inequality and complacency were the causes of much suffering. Priestley highlights the need to break down class barriers and embrace fairness across society.
➡️ *In your essay:* Priestley situates the play in an Edwardian world rigidly divided by class, using the Birlings to expose the moral blindness of a society where wealth determined worth and workers were voiceless.

3. Industrialisation and Workers' Rights

• Britain's prosperity depended on industries like coal mining and textiles, but workers faced long hours and low pay.
• Between **1910–1914**, the "**Great Unrest**" saw over **3 million workers** strike for better conditions.
• Priestley drew on his childhood in **industrial Bradford**, where he saw class divisions firsthand.
• Eva Smith's sacking mirrors these real disputes, representing the human cost of industrial capitalism.
• **Writer's Message:** By dramatising Eva's dismissal, Priestley condemns exploitative capitalism and urges his audience to support workers' rights and humane treatment.
➡️ *In your essay:* Drawing on the industrial unrest of 1910–14, Priestley portrays Eva Smith as a victim of a system that valued profit over people, reminding his audience of the real human cost of early capitalism.

4. Gender Inequality

• In 1912, women could not vote and were largely confined to domestic roles.
• The **suffragette movement**, led by **Emmeline Pankhurst** and the **WSPU**, fought for women's rights, often through protest and imprisonment.
• Women like Eva Smith worked in factories for half the wages of men, while middle-class women like Sheila were expected to marry for status.

• Social double standards meant women who defied convention were shamed, while men faced no consequence.
• **Writer's Message:** Priestley critiques a system that left women doubly vulnerable. He asks his audience to confront gender inequality and learn from the progress that had been won since 1912.
➡️ *In your essay:* By setting the play before women had the vote or basic workplace rights, Priestley critiques a patriarchal society that confined women like Sheila and punished those like Eva for seeking independence.

5. The Titanic and the Myth of Progress

• The Titanic, launched in **April 1912**, symbolised British engineering might and human progress.
• Its sinking, days later, killing **over 1,500 people**, shocked the nation.
• Birling's confidence that it is "unsinkable" captures the blind arrogance of industrial modernity and capitalist optimism.
• **Writer's Message:** The Titanic epitomises the dangers of arrogance. Priestley encourages his audience to distrust those who place blind faith in progress without considering human consequences.
➡️ *In your essay:* Birling's confidence in the "unsinkable" Titanic symbolises the blind faith of Edwardian industrialists in progress and technology — an irony that Priestley uses to ridicule capitalist overconfidence.

6. The Shadow of War

• The **First World War (1914–18)** killed 750,000 British soldiers and wounded many more.
• The **Second World War (1939–45)** caused even greater devastation, with over **60 million deaths worldwide**, including the Holocaust.
• Priestley fought in WWI and became a vocal advocate for peace and moral reform.
• The Inspector's warning of "fire and blood and anguish" evokes the horrors of both wars.
• **Writer's Message:** War is the ultimate price of selfishness. Priestley uses the Inspector's warning to remind audiences that peace depends on solidarity.
➡️ *In your essay:* Writing after two world wars that had exposed the cost of greed and nationalism, Priestley's warning of "fire and blood and anguish" urges his audience to see collective responsibility as the only path to peace.

7. The Rise of Socialism

• The early 20th century saw the growth of the **Labour movement** and trade unions.
• The **Great Depression (1929–1939)** led to mass unemployment and disillusionment with capitalism.
• Priestley's wartime radio broadcasts, *Postscripts* (1940–41), promoted unity and fairness.
• The Inspector embodies Priestley's socialist ideals — a moral guide rather than a literal detective.
• **Writer's Message:** Priestley presents socialism as moral common sense. His audience is urged to embrace collective responsibility rather than individual greed.
➡️ *In your essay:* Influenced by the growing socialist movement of the early twentieth century and the Labour victory of 1945, Priestley uses the Inspector as the voice of moral socialism, promoting fairness over self-interest.

8. The Welfare State and 1945 Britain

• After WWII, Britain sought a fairer society through reforms inspired by the **Beveridge Report (1942)**.
• The **Labour Government of 1945**, led by **Clement Attlee**, created the **NHS (1948)**, improved housing, and expanded education.
• Priestley's play, written that same year, echoed these ideals of care and equality.
• **Writer's Message:** The future must not mirror the past. Priestley aligns the Inspector's message with the principles of the new Welfare State, urging audiences to defend fairness and equality.
➡️ *In your essay:* For Priestley's postwar audience, the play echoed the new spirit of reform that had created the Welfare State, reinforcing the idea that society must protect its most vulnerable members.

9. Generational Shifts

• After the wars, younger generations rejected old hierarchies and values, seeking social renewal.
• Sheila and Eric embody this potential for change, contrasting with their parents' denial and conservatism.
• The idea of "learning responsibility" reflects postwar hopes for a more just future.
• **Writer's Message:** Priestley calls on younger generations to lead moral progress. The future depends on their willingness to reject denial and embrace responsibility.
➡️ *In your essay:* Through Sheila and Eric's willingness to change, Priestley reflects a postwar faith in younger generations to reject the complacency of their parents and build a fairer, more responsible world.

10. History as a Warning

• Set in 1912 but written in 1945, the play uses **dramatic irony** to expose the blindness of the past.
• Priestley's audience already knew the outcomes — the Titanic's sinking, two world wars, and social upheaval.
• Priestley, himself a WWI veteran, believed that history repeats when lessons are ignored.
• The Inspector becomes a moral prophet, warning humanity against complacency.
• **Writer's Message:** Learn from history, or be destroyed by it. Priestley warns his audience that selfishness and denial will always end in tragedy unless society accepts its duty to others.
➡️ *In your essay:* By contrasting the optimism of 1912 with the hindsight of 1945, Priestley turns *An Inspector Calls* into a moral warning that ignorance and selfishness, if unchecked, will always lead to destruction.